

# BIPOLAR II: THE SEQUEL

The first couple of times I was given the diagnosis bipolar II, I ignored it. I didn't tell my parents or my friends. I never followed up. I just pretended I hadn't heard it.

Bipolar is a mood disorder with two main mood swings: depression (down) and mania (up). Depression alone is a bit more common and, in my experience, easier for the average person to understand. But depression does not just mean sad. When I'm depressed, I'm in physical pain. Mania, or hypomania, is harder to grasp. Mania can be euphoric (nothing can stop you; you're the best) or depressive (mean, desperate). Either way, I stop thinking. I lose control.

Bipolar disorder is episodic. A person with bipolar can seem very stable for a long time and then suddenly go off the rails. Without medication, this is what happens to me.

The only time I'd privately hinted to another person that I might be bipolar was in a conversation with my mom when I was visiting from New York in 2011. We were sitting at the kitchen table, and I told her a therapist suggested the condition might apply to me. Her response was something about how all the women on her side of the family have "mood swings." I'd said, "Yes, bipolar disorder is genetic. It would make sense if we were all bipolar." She'd shrugged it off. A specific diagnosis didn't seem important to her; it was just a family curse. I never followed up on my therapist's opinion.

I'd always seen a talk therapist—either cheaply by going to a student therapist for a discount (twenty-five bucks a session) or, when I made some more money, going to a "real therapist." Changing therapists all the time depending on what you can afford isn't the best way to get consistent care. I told friends that I was in talk therapy. Because this was NYC, everyone who could afford it was in talk therapy, and those who couldn't wished they were. But seeing a psychiatrist was